

9 EDUCATION



Tell me and I forget. Teach me and I remember. Involve me and I learn.

Benjamin Franklin

It's possible to store the mind with a million facts and still be entirely uneducated.

Alec Bourne

□ VOCABULARY INPUT

Dealing with this topic you will come across the following vocabulary. Read it and look up the unknown words in your dictionary.

- **educational system:**

- pre-school education:* nursery school, kindergarten

- primary education:* primary school (Britain), elementary school (the USA)

- **secondary education:** secondary grammar school ("gymnázium"), comprehensive school (Britain), public school (Britain, the USA), high school (the USA), middle school (the USA), secondary vocational school (Slovakia),

- **higher/tertiary education:** college, university (undergraduate studies, graduate studies, postgraduate studies)

- **organisation of the school year:** term (BrE)/semester (AmE), timetable (BrE)/schedule (AmE), lessons, breaks, holidays

- **school subjects:** compulsory, optional, humanities (foreign language, literature, history, civic education, art, music), science (biology, chemistry, physics, maths, geometry, information technology), physical education (PE)

- **exams:** entrance exam, school leaving exam, midterm exam, final exam

- evaluation, criterion (pl. criteria), assessment, marks, school report, skill certificate, diploma

- to take (sit) an exam, to pass an exam, to fail an exam, to retake an exam, to succeed at the exam

- **people in education:** pupil, student, learner, teacher, professor, dean, headmaster/headmistress (headteacher)/principal (AmE), deputy, supervisor, course instructor, trainer, trainee, junior, senior, freshman, sophomore

- **students' activities:** to learn, to study, to acquire, to practise, to participate, to achieve, to be involved in, to improve in, to apply for, to be rewarded, to entertain, to enjoy, to sign up (some course), to perform, to do homework, to hand in an assignment on time, to make mistakes, to defend (a diploma work)

- **teachers' activities:** to teach, to explain, to facilitate, to share, to support, to encourage, to examine, to test, to mark essays, to evaluate, to provide with feedback, to consult, to recommend, to involve students in

- **extracurricular activities:** clubs, sport teams, school orchestra, chess club, painting, pottery, radio club, filming, drama club, literary club, horse riding, taking photography

- **problems at schools:** disciplinary problems, lack of finances, lack of motivation, lack of respect, poor cooperation between teachers and parents, bullying, cribbing, playing truant, skipping classes, being expelled from school, not fulfilling the necessary criteria to obtain credit, failing exams

□ DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

Before reading the text, discuss the following questions in class.

1. Which kind of school do you attend?
2. What do you like/dislike about the school you attend?
3. Which class are you in?
4. How do you get on with your classmates and your teachers?
5. Which are your favourite subjects? Why?
6. Which after-school activities does your school offer?
7. What are the qualities of a good teacher?
8. What are the qualities of a good learner?
9. Would you ever like to be a teacher? If yes, at which type of school? Which subject would you like to teach?
10. What is the role of teachers in our society? Are teachers more/less respected than they were in the past? Why?

□ TEXT

Read the texts below in silence. Check the meaning of the words in bold and answer the questions below.

Most people realise that a good **qualification** is very important for a successful career. Educational systems and types of degrees vary from country to country.

THE BRITISH SCHOOL SYSTEM

The educational system in England, Scotland, Wales and Northern Ireland differs. Primary education starts, in fact, in a **nursery school** and **kindergarten**. British children begin their education at the age of 5 and must **attend** school to the age of 16. In Britain, there are state schools and **public schools**. The **majority** of British children are educated in state schools which are **free of charge**. There are many public schools in Britain, mainly for the 13–18 age group. Many of them are **private boarding schools** which are **peculiar to** Britain. The most exclusive ones, with a long tradition, are *Eton*, *Harrow* and *Winchester*. Their tuition **fees** are very high. Children in Britain continue to study at a secondary school: 1. **comprehensive schools** (which offer a **general education**), 2. **grammar schools** (which prepare students for university study), 3. **modern schools** (which **provide** general **education** and **focus** more **on** practical activities), 4. technical schools (which put **emphasis** on education in the areas of industry, commerce and agriculture). This ends at the age of sixteen when most pupils take some form of public examination in eight to ten **subjects**. These *General Certificate of Secondary Education* (GCSE) exams are national and give **pupils** a qualification that is **recognised** across the whole country. Most pupils continue their further education after sixteen, for another

two years, in the sixth **form** (two extra years at school) or at **college**. During these two years, students take a more academic form of study leading to **advanced** examinations (A-Levels) in two to four subjects. These examinations are very important for those who want to go on into higher education: 1. universities, 2. polytechnics and 3. colleges of higher education (for future teachers for example). The oldest and the most **prestigious** British universities include *Oxford University* and *Cambridge University*. The most common titles for those who have **graduated from university** are BA (Bachelor of Arts), BSc (Bachelor of Science), BEd (Bachelor of Education). Postgraduate titles are MA (Master of Arts), MSc (Master of Science), PhD (Doctor of Philosophy).

1. When do British children start going to schools?
2. Which types of secondary schools are there in Britain?
3. What is the difference between further education and higher education?

THE AMERICAN SCHOOL SYSTEM

Americans take great pride in their schools and want their children, as parents do everywhere, to have the best possible education. There is great **variety** and flexibility in elementary, secondary and higher education throughout the country. Each state is **responsible** for its own educational system. There are both state and private schools in the USA. Private schools are smaller and are usually supported by church groups or by private funds. Private school pupils pay their tuition. Most American children attend state schools. American state schools are called public schools (which should not be **confused** with British public schools – those are actually private). Three levels can be **distinguished** in the American public school system: 1. **Elementary** (Kindergarten – 6th grade), 2. **Middle School** (6th – 8th grade), 3. **High School** (9th – 12th grade). At high schools students have both **compulsory** and **optional** subjects. At the end of the final year at high school, students take a **nation-wide** test, called the *Scholastic Achievement Test (SAT)* in all subjects and the scores are used for college **entrance requirements**. About half of all young people who **graduate** from American high schools continue their education at colleges and universities. The USA has some of the world's most **outstanding** universities including *Harvard University* (Massachusetts), *Yale University* (Connecticut), *Princeton University* (New Jersey) amongst others.

4. What have you learned from the text about private and state schools?
5. What is the difference between public schools in Britain and public schools in America?
6. What is the "SAT"?

THE SLOVAK SCHOOL SYSTEM

In Slovakia, **pre-school** education starts at kindergarten. **School attendance** is compulsory from the age of 6 when pupils start attending either state schools, private schools or church schools. The school year lasts ten months and it is divided into two **terms**. At the end of each term, students get a **school report** with **marks** for almost all subjects.

Primary education takes nine years at primary school. However, some students start their studies at “8-year grammar schools” as soon as they finish the 5th grade of primary school. Most students start the secondary level of education after **finishing** the 9th grade of primary school. Those students who want to get into “*gymnázium*” (secondary grammar school or high school) have to take **entrance exams**. This type of school is very popular since it prepares students for university study. It is also highly **selective** and only the **best applicants** are taken. The five-year study programme is sometimes bilingual. *Stredná odborná škola* (secondary vocational school) includes secondary business schools, technical schools and medical schools. *Združená stredná škola* (secondary “grouped” school) and their **training centres** prepare students for different kinds of professions. Studies usually last four years and end with a **school leaving exam** called “*maturita*”. This exam is very important because its results **are taken into account** when students apply for university studies.

However, most students in our country have to **pass** entrance **exams** to be **accepted** into most universities. Applicants can decide whether they want to **study part-time or full-time**. The largest and oldest Slovak university is *Comenius University* in Bratislava. During university studies many students decide to spend a term or a year at a foreign university as **exchange students**. Many Slovak university students and graduates work abroad during the summer because it is an excellent opportunity to make some money, speak a foreign language, see new cultures and meet new people. Studying or working abroad is extremely useful for them because they improve their foreign language skills and get to know new cultures. They also learn to live independently. This often makes them more **self-confident**. In recent years, the European Union has tried to reform higher education across the whole of Europe. In 2005, a new “*maturita exam*” (school leaving exam) was introduced. Its main goal was to **unify** written tests and **standardise** other exams. Furthermore, the Anglo-American BA (bachelor) – MA (master’s) **degree** system has been introduced.

7. What types of secondary schools are there in Slovakia? What do they prepare their students for?

8. In which aspects does the Slovak school system differ from the American and the British?

EXTRACURRICULAR ACTIVITIES

There are many different clubs and sports teams at schools which meet after lessons. Many schools publish their own student newspapers and some have their own radio station. At secondary schools in our country many students spend their free time attending language courses or extra lessons to prepare themselves for the school leaving exam and university entrance exams. In Britain and the USA, many schools have an orchestra that gives concerts or a drama group that **stages a play** at Christmas. In the USA there are school teams that play baseball, basketball and American football against other schools.

9. According to the text which activities do schools offer after standard lessons?

10. Does your school offer any of them?

SUMMARY

Once you have read the text above, quickly scan the following chart. Work in groups of three. Study the basic information about one of the school systems provided below. Then, report the information to other students in your group. Compare and contrast the facts. Explain which school system you consider to be the best and explain your reasons.

	Slovakia	Britain	The USA
Compulsory schooling	9 years	11 years	11 years
Pre-school education	<i>Jasle</i> (Nursery school) <i>Škôlka</i> (Kindergarten)	Nursery school Playgroups Kindergarten	Nursery school Kindergarten
Attendance starts at the age of	6	5	5
Primary education	<i>Základná škola</i> (Primary school) 1–4 year 5–9 year	Primary school a) Infant school (age 5–6) b) Junior school (age 7–10)	Elementary school (1 st –6 th grade)
Secondary education	Types of secondary schools: a) <i>gymnázium</i> : grammar school b) <i>stredná odborná škola</i> : secondary vocational school c) <i>združená stredná škola</i> : secondary “grouped” school	Types of secondary schools: a) comprehensive schools b) grammar schools c) modern schools d) technical schools GCSE exam: at the age of 16	Types of secondary schools: a) Middle School (6 th –8 th grade) b) High School (9 th –12 th grade)
EXAM	<i>Maturita</i> (school leaving exam)	A-level exam (at the age of 17/18)	Scholastic Achievement Test (SAT)
Higher education	<i>Vysoká škola</i> (college) <i>Universities</i> : – state university – private university	a) University b) Polytechnic c) College of Further Education	a) University b) College: – Junior College – Senior College
Organisation of the school year	two semesters	three terms	two semesters or three trimesters

- adapted from <http://en.wikipedia.org>)

□ VOCABULARY LIST

- to accept to** – prijať do
advanced – pokročilý
applicant – uchádzač
to attend (school) – navštevovať školu
college [kɒlɪdʒ] – vysoká škola
comprehensive school – stredná všeobecná-vzdelávacia škola
compulsory [kəm'pʌlsəri] – povinný
to confuse [kən'fju:z] – zmiatať
degree – akademická hodnosť, titul
to distinguish – rozlíšiť
elementary school (AmE) – základná škola
emphasis – dôraz
entrance exams – prijímacie skúšky
entrance requirements [ɪnkwaiəmənts] – požiadavky na prijatie
exchange student – študent na výmennom pobyte
to focus on – sústrediť sa na
free of charge – bez poplatku, zadarmo
grade (AmE) – trieda, ročník
graduate – absolvent (BrE: univerzity, AmE: strednej školy)
grammar school – stredná škola (gymnázium)
high school (AmE) – stredná škola
kindergarten – materská škola
majority [mə'dʒɒrəti] – väčšina
mark – známka v škole
middle school – stredná škola
modern school (BrE) – stredná škola
nationwide – celoštátny
nursery school – materská škôlka
optional [ɒpʃnəl] – voliteľný
outstanding – vynikajúci
peculiar (to) – príznačný, typický (pre)
polytechnic (BrE) [pɒli'teknik] – škola vyššieho vzdelania technického zamerania
postgraduate – doktorand, doktorandský
pre-school [pri:sku:l] – predškolský
prestigious [pre'stɪdʒəs] – prestížny, významný
primary education – základné vzdelanie
private boarding school – súkromná internátna škola
public school [pʌblɪk] – stredná škola (BrE: súkromná, AmE: štátna)
pupil – [pju:pl] žiak
qualification – kvalifikácia
to recognise – uznávať
responsible (for) – zodpovedný (za)
school attendance – školská dochádzka
school-leaving exam – záverečná skúška maturita
school report – vysvedčenie
selective – výberový, selektívny
self-confident – sebavedomý, sebaistý
sixth form – šiesta trieda (pre 16-ročných)
to standardise [stændədaɪz] (AmE: standardize) – štandardizovať
technical school – technická škola
term (BrE) – semester
training centre – školiace stredisko
tuition fee – školné
to unify [ju:nɪfaɪ] – zjednotiť
variety [və'raɪəti] – rozmanitosť, výber
to take into account – (zo)brať do úvahy
to graduate from university – absolvovať, vyštudovať univerzitu
to pass an exam – zložiť skúšku
to provide education – poskytovať vzdelanie
to stage a play – (z)inscenovať hru
to study full-time – študovať denne
to study part-time – študovať diaľkovo

□ VOCABULARY PRACTICE

Task 1 Make the pairs from the following words. Sometimes, there are more possible combinations.

Example: school attendance

secondary – training – school – compulsory – entrance – subjects

exam – primary – extracurricular – elective – sport – title – activities –
teams – centres – bilingual – final – midterm – report – marks – boarding
– education – postgraduate – tertiary – system – leaving – vocational –
academic – level – evaluation – optional

Task 2 Add the verbs in column A to the words in column B to make well-known phrases.



A

B

Example: to acquire

g

1. to attend
2. to bully
3. to grant
4. to pass
5. to play
6. to mark
7. to pay
8. to examine
9. to skip
10. to be expelled
11. to cheat with
12. to apply for
13. to memorise
14. to learn

- a) a classmate
- b) a scholarship
- c) an exam
- d) attention
- e) students
- f) essays
- g) knowledge
- h) a school
- i) truant
- j) by heart
- k) crib sheets
- l) from school
- m) definitions
- n) university study
- o) classes

Task 3 Are the following words connected with primary/secondary/university education or with extracurricular activities?

1

a student – a pupil – a teacher – a headmaster – a supervisor
a lecturer – a professor – a dean – a coach – a deputy – a vice-dean
a trainee – a freshman – a sophomore – a trainer – a rector

Task 4 Express your opinion. What qualities make a good teacher? What qualities make a good student? Talk about them and use the adjectives in the box below.

strict – fair – tolerant – responsible – democratic – authoritative –
creative – interested – clever – informed – educated – narrow-minded
– easy-going – frustrated – flexible – liberal – friendly – hardworking
– experienced – broad-minded – ambitious – respectful – motivated –
demanding – facilitative – anxious – tense – pleasant – honest –
conservative – empathic – curious – responsive – malicious – traditional –
innovative

□ REVIEW

Task 12 Correct the following translations. Be careful as all translations are wrong because they are either **FALSE FRIENDS** (a word in a foreign language which appears similar to a word in your language but with a totally different meaning) or **NEGATIVE TRANSFERS** from Slovak.



SLOVAK EQUIVALENT	WRONG TRANSLATION	CORRECT TRANSLATION
promócie	<i>promotion</i>	a)
stredoškolský professor	<i>professor</i>	b)
gymnázium	<i>gymnasium</i>	c)
maturita	<i>maturity</i>	d)
základná škola	<i>basic school</i>	e)
vysoká škola	<i>high school</i>	f)
písať písomku/test	<i>write an exam</i>	g)
pani učiteľka Fosterová	<i>Mrs. teacher Fosterová</i>	h)
tabuľa	<i>table</i>	i)

Task 13 What is the difference in meaning between the following words?
If you are not sure, check the meaning in your dictionary.

a) high school/college/university

b) faculty/department

c) to take an exam/sit an exam/pass an exam/fail an exam/retake an exam

d) homework/essay/assignment

e) lesson/hour

f) classmate/schoolmate/roommate/flatmate

g) college/colleague

h) professor/teacher

i) class/classroom

j) pupil/student